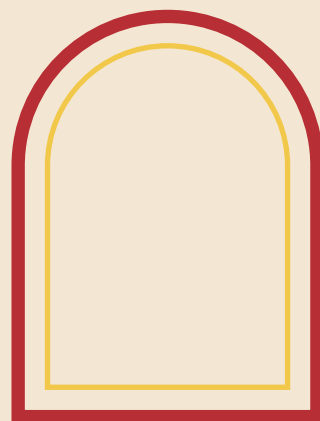


smol café

brand kit

A warm, literary neighbourhood café with a day-to-night personality - built for long stays, good coffee, food, music, conversation and the people who become part of the place.



version 1.0 / august 2026 / logo intentionally excluded

brand snapshot

The fastest way to understand how smol should look, sound and behave.

small place. long stay.

The brand should make people think: "I want to sit there for three hours" and "this feels like a café from an old movie" - without becoming costume-retro or overly precious.

warm

human before polished

nostalgic

familiar without imitation

imperfect

designed, never sterile

youthful

curious, not childish

intellectual

bookish, not self-serious

THE BRAND IS NOT

- a beige wellness café with generic yoga language
- a 1950s diner theme or nostalgia costume
- a neon nightclub during the day
- a specialty-coffee lab that feels clinical
- a "community" brand that forces interaction or over-explains itself

what smol owns

The experience is the product as much as the menu.

a café people remember because stories happen there.

POSITIONING

For travellers, locals, couples, creatives, hotel guests and people passing through Rishikesh, smol café is the warm neighbourhood café where great Indian coffee, comfort food, music and conversation can turn an ordinary stop into part of the trip.

- stay a while
Comfort, low pressure, familiar tables, readable menus, places to linger.
- conversation over transaction
The space makes room for talking, reading, observing and meeting without forcing it.
- familiar + curious
Known comforts sit beside small experiments, local ingredients and slightly unexpected programming.
- day / night duality
The core identity stays consistent while colour, pace, lighting, type behaviour and programming change.

who we are speaking to

One brand, several reasons to walk through the door.

the traveller

Wants a place worth remembering, not another generic Tapovan café. Values atmosphere, local discovery and a story to tell later.

the regular

Local, long-stay guest or repeat visitor. Needs consistency, approachable pricing, comfort food and a place that becomes routine.

the creative / remote worker

Likes coffee, books, music and a place with visual personality. Needs calm in the day without the café turning into a silent coworking office.

the couple / friend group

Wants an easy plan that can stretch: coffee to food, conversation to music, afternoon to evening.

the socially curious guest

Open to listening sessions, creative tables, conversation prompts and recurring events - but does not want forced networking.

"invite people in; never make them perform belonging."

personality in practice

Use these tensions to make decisions when a creative feels "almost smol".

warm

not sugary

clever

not smug

retro

not themed

social

not forced

artistic

not messy

young

not juvenile

intellectual

not academic

local

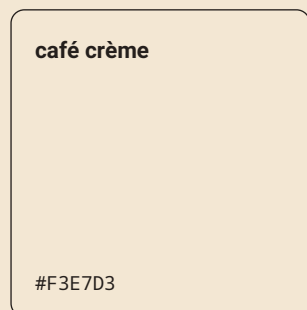
not folkloric

THE 3-SECOND TEST

Would this feel natural on a table in a lived-in 90s neighbourhood café, inside an old paperback, or on a small cultural poster - while still working clearly in 2026?

the locked palette

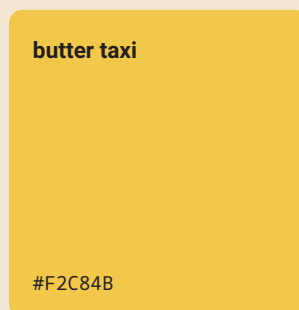
Core neutrals + one iconic hero colour, with controlled day/night accents.



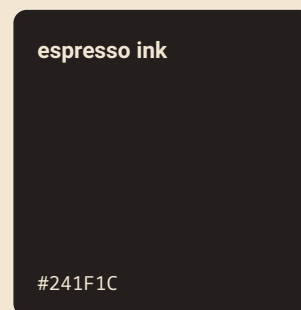
CMYK 0 5 13 5



CMYK 0 75 71 28



CMYK 0 17 69 5



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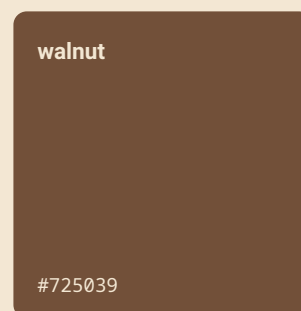
CMYK 0 13 31 21



CMYK 54 70 0 0



CMYK 33 0 5 31



CMYK 0 30 50 55

CMYK values are starting conversions only. Always print-proof on the actual stock and printer process before production.

hierarchy + contrast

Colour should create recognition, not visual noise.

core ratio



PAIRING	RATIO	USE	STATUS
espresso ink on café crème	13.34:1	best for body copy	PASS
smol cherry on café crème	4.97:1	normal text + headlines	PASS
walnut on café crème	5.88:1	secondary copy	PASS
electric violet on café crème	4.06:1	large text / accent only	CAUTION
butter taxi on café crème	1.31:1	background / decoration only	NO SMALL TEXT
café crème on espresso ink	13.34:1	night body copy	PASS
butter taxi on espresso ink	10.20:1	night utility text	PASS
dusty pool on espresso ink	6.56:1	secondary night accent	PASS

non-negotiables

- Never use Butter Taxi for small text on Crème.
- Do not set Cherry as small text on Espresso; use Crème, Biscuit or Butter instead.
- Electric Violet is a night/collaboration accent, not a daytime primary.
- Keep most layouts to one neutral + Cherry + one accent.

smol by day

Coffee, food, daylight, books, flowers, slow conversations. Airier and warmer - never pale or generic.



slow mornings

coffee · conversations · sunlight

- Crème is the canvas. White should be rare.
- Cherry leads recognition; yellow is a spark, not a field of colour.
- Use generous margins and relaxed serif headlines.
- Natural daylight, warm wood and imperfect paper textures are part of the visual identity.
- Dusty Pool appears as an environmental surprise - ceramics, small graphics, upholstery, illustration.

day content should show

- sunlight on tables
- half-finished coffee
- hands, books, notes
- flowers and window details
- food in context, not isolated
- people staying, not posing

familiar before polished

smol after dark

Same brand. Different behaviour. Music, stories, low light, direct flash, recurring nights and VYBE-compatible energy.



late coffee. deep talks.

FRIDAY · 8:30 PM · LISTENING SESSION

- Type gets tighter, larger and more poster-like; the font families do not change.
- Violet enters as a controlled accent (roughly 5-12%), not a full purple wash.
- Use Crème or Butter for functional information on Espresso backgrounds.
- Direct flash + warm lamp light can coexist. Avoid nightclub-blue colour grading.
- Keep Cherry present so day and night still belong to the same café.

VYBE CROSSOVER RULE

VYBE may change the energy, lighting and accent colour. It must not replace smol's palette, typography or warm hospitality tone. Co-branded nights should still look like they happened at smol.

the type system

Final direction: old paperback / 90s coffeehouse editorial + clean Swiss utility + literary mono.

All three recommended families are free / open-source and suitable for team-wide installation.

01 / PRIMARY EDITORIAL - EB GARAMOND

a table worth staying at

old paperback warmth without costume nostalgia.

02 / FUNCTIONAL SANS - INTER

menu · signage · website · captions · wayfinding

Inter carries information cleanly so the editorial serif can keep its personality. Use Regular, Medium and SemiBold; avoid Black as a default.

03 / LITERARY UTILITY - NOTO SANS MONO

SAT 08 AUG · 7:30 PM · TABLE 04

Use for dates, times, prices, labels, tiny editorial notes and event information. It gives the system a typewriter-ish rhythm without becoming themed.

ANNOTATION STYLE

use italic serif like a quick margin note - never a cute script font.

This keeps the system human while staying literary and easy for the team to reproduce.

how type behaves

The same fonts can feel quiet by day and more cultural at night.

APPROVED TEXT TREATMENTS - NOT LOGO LOCKUPS

smol café

loose / calm / day

smol café

tight/poster/night

smol
café

stacked/editorial

recommended hierarchy

hero/poster	EB Garamond Bold	40-72 pt print / 48-96 px digital
section heading	EB Garamond Bold	22-34 pt / 28-44 px
body	Inter Regular	9.5-11.5 pt / 16-18 px
utility/prices	Noto Sans Mono	8-10 pt / 12-15 px
annotation	EB Garamond Italic	10-16 pt / 16-24 px

DO NOT

- Capitalize the brand name as SMOL CAFE in consumer-facing work.
- Use more than three font families in one asset.
- Use decorative script fonts for warmth.
- Stretch or condense fonts non-proportionally.
- Use the serif for long blocks of small functional copy.

graphic language

Designed like a lived-in cultural café: editorial structure + imperfect human traces.

arched frames

Use the door/arch geometry as a crop, border, window or label shape. Do not repeat the actual logo mark as decoration.

editorial rules

Thin lines, underlines, circles, margin notes and offset captions. Think old magazines and small event posters.

print texture

Paper grain, ink softness, mild misregistration and photocopy texture may appear on expressive assets - never on essential text.

micro motifs

Four-point stars, tiny dots, underlines, simple botanical or everyday-object line drawings. Keep them sparse.

checks, selectively

Checkerboard can appear on a coaster, edge, table card or poster detail. Never make it the entire brand.

botanical warmth

Flowers and plants can connect the exterior, photography and illustration language without turning the café into a floral brand.

AVOID

coffee-bean clipart · literal steaming-cup logos · neon gradients · chrome 3D · excessive cherries · boho mandalas · generic mountain silhouettes · full-page checkerboard · random "retro" fonts

photography direction

People and atmosphere first. Food is part of the scene, not the whole story.

people + moments



60%

space + details



25%

food + drinks



15%

by day

- natural window light
- warm white balance
- hands, books, notebooks
- cups in use, not product shots
- flowers, wood, paper, fabric
- slightly imperfect compositions
- visible signs of people staying

after dark

- warm lamp pools + direct flash
- motion and candid faces
- records, tables, event details
- deep shadows, not crushed blacks
- violet as real light accent
- no nightclub-blue wash
- show connection, not crowd size

"document the place people want to return to - not a showroom."

how smol speaks

Lowercase, conversational, specific, lightly witty. Never try too hard to sound cool.

human

Write like the person behind the counter has taste, not like a hospitality group.

dry + warm

Humour is a small eyebrow raise. Avoid punchlines on every line.

specific

Say "listening session, 8 pm" instead of "an unforgettable evening of vibes".

low-pressure

Invite. Do not manufacture urgency or exclusivity.

slightly literary

Short observations, margins, notes and quiet lines are stronger than motivational copy.

CURRENT MENU LANGUAGE THAT ALREADY FEELS ON-BRAND

slow mornings

got the munchies?

i need actual food

we did something weird

chai, chaas & other good decisions

AVOID LANGUAGE LIKE

"escape the ordinary" · "soulful vibes" · "guilt-free" · "a sanctuary" · "where magic happens" · "limited seats!!!" · overly spiritual café clichés

how the system shows up

The identity should remain easy to print, easy to reproduce and recognisable in one or two colours.

menus

Crème stock; Cherry editorial headings; Espresso body; Mono prices and dietary notes. Keep section names conversational.

cups + takeaway

Prefer Crème base with one-colour Cherry or Espresso print. Two-colour Cherry + Butter for selected runs.

event posters

One oversized serif headline; mono date/time/location; tighter spacing at night; Violet only as controlled accent.

signage + wayfinding

High contrast first. Espresso/Cherry on Crème. Use short language and consistent arrow/line styles.

social

Alternate candid photography, text-led editorial cards, menu moments and recurring event identities. Do not make every post a designed poster.

merch

Screen-print friendly, 1-2 colours, large simple typography or approved logo asset once final. Avoid over-detailed illustrations.

team non-negotiables

- Write the brand name as "smol café" in lowercase.
- Do not introduce new colours without a brand-system update.
- Use only EB Garamond, Inter and Noto Sans Mono for core communication.
- Keep assets printable in one colour whenever possible.
- The logo is managed as a separate asset and is intentionally not included in this document.

one-page team cheat sheet

When in doubt, use this page.

NAME smol café - always lowercase

CORE café crème + smol cherry + espresso ink

DAY add butter taxi; airy serif layouts; daylight

NIGHT add electric violet; tighter type; warm lamps + flash

TYPE EB Garamond / Inter / Noto Sans Mono

VOICE warm, specific, lightly witty, low-pressure

PHOTO people and atmosphere before product perfection

GRAPHIC editorial lines, arch framing, print texture, sparse motifs

NEVER wellness cliché, diner costume, neon overload, random retro fonts

BEFORE PUBLISHING

Check: lowercase name · approved palette · correct type family · readable contrast · one clear idea · still feels warm in black-and-white.

what is locked vs open

This guide is detailed enough for day-to-day design production while leaving room for final identity assets.

locked

- Brand name styling: smol café, lowercase.
- Brand personality: warm, nostalgic, imperfect, youthful, intellectual.
- Colour palette and day/night role of the colours.
- Typography direction and accessible core families: EB Garamond, Inter, Noto Sans Mono.
- Day/night identity behaviour and VYBE crossover principle.
- Graphic, photography and tone-of-voice direction.

still open

- Final logo master files and lockups (managed separately).
- Exact exterior signage fabrication details and final dimensions.
- Final packaging dielines and print vendor specifications.
- Event-series names and recurring poster templates after programming is locked.
- Any future sub-brand or retail product architecture.

INTERNAL SOURCE BASIS

Built from the Smol Door Café project context, the current Rishikesh market / menu research, current menu-engineering language, the approved colour palette, and typography decisions made in the working brand-development conversation. This is an internal operational brand guide, not a legal trademark manual.

last updated: 12 aug 2026